

CSS Zen designs

Bronze

This design greets with the focal point front and center. As Hagen, Rebecca, and Kim Golombisky (2017, 71) explain the focal point can be compared to a big sign where all the content starts.

In this case, the focal point takes up the entire screen, and clearly establishes a theme. When scrolling down the content is neatly ordered in the center. It also Uses color in a few places to emphasize the illustrations. The minimal use of color makes it impactful to the design. It also keeps to a consistent style effectively, while managing to feel different while scrolling down.

Link: <https://csszengarden.com/218/>

Silver

This design is a great example of simplicity. Most of the page is just the white background, however this adds to the design. The designer can use empty space to communicate. As Hagen, Rebecca, and Kim Golombisky (2017, 56) explain, negative design or white space is the most effective design tool.

As Hagen, Rebecca, and Kim Golombisky (2017, 56) explain, contrast is key to creating interesting design, and there is limitless way to create contrast. In the case of this design, they achieve it simply with black rectangle on white background, where the black box has visual interest with foliage poking out on all sides.

Link: <https://csszengarden.com/171>

Gold

With this design, rules are out the window. If you were to explain it, where it has odd text sections, messy layout, small text and many varying fonts it would sound like a bad looking site. However, the design is still cool and readable because the designer clearly knows the fundamentals and can bend the rules because of that.

The color choices are also very bold and saturated. With heavy contrast, using red on black. With splashes of white for visual emphasis, as Hagen, Rebecca, and Kim Golombisky (2017, 126) explain, splashes of color can be effective to add interest. Where well chosen spots can highlight certain focal points.

The theme of the site also clearly mirrors that of breaking design rules. Where they add words of defiance and criticizing the template text. I think this design is a good example of

breaking rules to achieve a unique look, while also showcasing why fundamentals are important. “Bottom line: Don’t break the rules of design out of ignorance. Learn the rules. Then break the rules if you have a reason to.” is how Hagen, Rebecca, and Kim Golombisky (2017, 7) summarize this.

Link: <https://csszengarden.com/107/>

Sources

Hagen, Rebecca, and Kim Golombisky. 2017. *White Space Is Not Your Enemy : A Beginner’s Guide to Communicating Visually through Graphic, Web & Multimedia Design*. 3rd ed. Boca Raton, Fla: CRC Press.